SCARECROW WATCH · METHODOLOGY

Scoring rubric: rating risk factors 1–5

How Scarecrow Lab assigns a 1–5 score to each risk factor in the UN Framework of Analysis for Atrocity Crimes and the AIPG PREVENT framework.

Version: October 2026 · Scarecrow Lab · scarecrowlab@proton.me · Published for transparency; apply with the Berkeley Protocol.

Every risk factor is rated on a 1 (minimal) to 5 (severe) scale. Some factors are scored automatically from public data against fixed thresholds; others are judged by analysts. This rubric sets the shared criteria for both, so scores are consistent between analysts and open to scrutiny by anyone.

A · How scoring works

- **Two ways a factor is scored. Automated** indicators are scored from public datasets (World Bank, V-Dem, UCDP) against the fixed thresholds in Section E. **Analyst-judged** indicators are rated by a Lab analyst using the anchors in Sections C–D.
- **The general ladder (Section B) governs every analyst-judged score.** The per-factor anchors show what that ladder looks like for each specific factor.
- **Averaging.** A PREVENT category score is the average of its indicators; the structural index is the average of the six structural categories (P, R, E, V, E, N). Triggers (T, and UN Factor 8) are flagged separately and never averaged in.
- **Direction.** A higher number always means higher risk — including for "absence of mitigating factors", where fewer safeguards score higher.
- **Human check on automation.** An automated score that moves by more than one step from the last published score is held for four-eyes review before it goes public.

B · The general 1–5 ladder

The backbone for every analyst-judged factor. Read the three lenses together.

SCORE	PRESENCE / PREVALENCE	REACH & SAFEGUARDS	TREND
1 **Minimal**	Factor absent or effectively contained.	Functioning safeguards; no credible recent indications.	Stable or improving.
2 **Low**	Isolated, localised or latent indications.	Factor exists but limited in scope; safeguards mostly hold.	Stable.
3 **Moderate**	Clearly present and material.	Recurring or significant indications across part of the country or a group; safeguards strained.	Mixed or uncertain.

4 **High**	Strong, widespread or escalating.	Affects whole groups or regions; safeguards weak or failing. Corroborated reporting.	Worsening.
5 **Severe**	Pervasive, acute, or actively enabling / driving atrocity-level harm.	Safeguards absent or captured. Extensive, well-documented evidence.	Acute or rapidly worsening.

When the evidence sits between two levels, record the lower score and note the uncertainty. A score of 4 or 5 requires corroboration from at least two independent, credible sources.

C · UN Framework of Analysis — 8 risk factors

The eight common risk factors shown on each country's radar. Full 1–5 anchors.

1 Conflict / instability

Situations of armed conflict or other forms of instability.

1 No armed conflict; political order stable.
2 Sporadic unrest or tension; no organised violence.
3 Localised or low-intensity armed conflict / recurrent instability.
4 Significant armed conflict affecting regions or groups; institutions strained.
5 Widespread or intensifying armed conflict; state authority breaking down.

2 Record of serious violations

A past or present record of serious violations of international human-rights and humanitarian law.

1 No recent pattern of serious violations.
2 Occasional serious violations; generally investigated.
3 Recurring serious violations; accountability weak and uneven.
4 Widespread violations with emerging patterns and broad impunity.
5 Systematic, widespread violations; entrenched impunity; past atrocities unaddressed.

3 Weak state structures

Weakness of the state structures and institutions that would normally prevent atrocity crimes.

1 Capable, accountable institutions; independent judiciary, oversight and civil society.
2 Institutions broadly functional with some gaps or pressure.
3 Institutions partly captured, under-resourced or unevenly present.
4 Institutions largely unable or unwilling to protect; oversight failing.
5 Institutions absent, captured or complicit; no effective check on executive or security forces.

4 Motives / incentives

The presence of motives or incentives to commit atrocity crimes.

1. No discernible incentive to target a group.
2. Latent grievances or rivalries that could be mobilised.
3. Emerging incentives: power consolidation, resource or territorial disputes, scapegoating.
4. Clear incentives articulated by influential actors against a group.
5. Explicit, sustained motive to harm or remove a group; a group framed as an existential threat.

5 Capacity to commit

The capacity (means and organisation) to commit atrocity crimes.

1. No organised armed capacity able to target civilians at scale.
2. Armed forces or groups exist but without evident intent or reach.
3. Latent capacity; some arming, recruitment or mobilisation.
4. Organised, resourced forces with growing reach and command.
5. Organised, resourced forces with demonstrated reach and logistics to target civilians.

6 Absence of mitigating factors

The absence of factors that would otherwise reduce risk. Scored so that FEWER mitigants = HIGHER score.

1. Strong mitigants: free media, active civil society, rule of law, international presence.
2. Mitigants present but under some pressure.
3. Mitigants weakening: shrinking civic space, pressured media, limited external attention.
4. Few mitigants remain; most checks neutralised.
5. Mitigants absent: civic space closed, media captured, no credible deterrent or presence.

7 Enabling circumstances / preparatory action

Circumstances or preparatory acts that enable or signal planning of atrocity crimes.

1. No preparatory steps or enabling measures.
2. Isolated discriminatory measures or hostile rhetoric.
3. Early enablers: hate speech, discriminatory measures, registration or profiling of a group.
4. Advancing preparation: incitement, arming of militias, movement restrictions on a group.
5. Advanced preparation: systematic incitement, dehumanising propaganda, isolation or denial of access, mobilisation.

8 Triggering factors

Specific events or circumstances that could spark atrocity crimes. Flagged separately, not averaged into the index.

1. No imminent trigger on the horizon.
2. A distant or low-probability trigger.
3. A plausible trigger ahead: contested election, leadership transition, anniversary, court verdict.
4. A likely near-term trigger, or heightened tension around one.
5. An active flashpoint underway: disputed result, assassination, offensive, mass mobilisation.

D · PREVENT — analyst-judged indicators

The twelve PREVENT indicators rated by analysts. Full 1–5 anchors. (Letter = PREVENT category.)

P Prior atrocity crimes

1 None in modern history.
2 Distant atrocity, now addressed.
3 Historical atrocity, partially addressed or still contested.
4 Atrocity within living memory, largely unaddressed.
5 Recent or ongoing atrocity, unaddressed.

P Prior armed conflict

1 No armed conflict in a generation.
2 Old conflict, durable peace.
3 Past conflict, fragile peace or frozen dispute.
4 Conflict within the last decade; unresolved drivers.
5 Recent or recurring armed conflict.

P Prior widespread human-rights violations

1 No pattern of widespread abuses.
2 Isolated past abuses, reformed.
3 Periodic serious violations.
4 Sustained violations in recent years.
5 Systematic, documented violations, ongoing or recent.

R Coups or extralegal leadership change

1 Stable constitutional transfers of power.
2 Orderly transfers; old instability.
3 Contested or irregular transfers, or recent attempts.
4 Recent attempted or partial extralegal seizure.
5 Recent successful coup or extralegal seizure of power.

E Factionalism

1 Broad, cross-cutting politics.
2 Some polarisation, managed.
3 Polarisation along identity or regional lines.
4 Deep factional blocs capturing institutions.
5 Severe, zero-sum factionalism; the state is a prize fought over by identity blocs.

E Low regime durability

1 Long-stable, legitimate order.
2 Established order, minor strain.
3 Recent or volatile regime; legitimacy questioned.
4 Unstable regime; frequent crises.
5 Brittle, contested or newly imposed regime.

V Economic discrimination between groups

1 No group-based economic exclusion.
2 Minor disparities, not policy-driven.
3 Notable disparities or discrimination against a group.
4 Deliberate economic marginalisation of a group.
5 Systematic economic exclusion of a group.

V Environmental & climate stress

1 Low climate or resource stress.
2 Occasional shocks, absorbed.
3 Recurring shocks straining livelihoods.
4 Severe stress driving competition or displacement.
5 Acute climate or resource crisis fuelling conflict or mass displacement.

E Exclusionary ideology

1 Inclusive public discourse.
2 Fringe exclusionary voices only.
3 Exclusionary rhetoric gaining traction in mainstream politics.
4 Exclusionary ideology adopted by influential actors.
5 Dominant ideology that dehumanises or targets a group.

E State-led discrimination

1 Equal treatment in law and practice.
2 Minor unequal practice, contested.
3 Discriminatory laws or practice against a group.
4 Entrenched discrimination across services and rights.
5 Systematic state-led discrimination: citizenship, movement or rights stripped.

E Salient elite drawn from one group

1 Power broadly shared across groups.
2 Mild over-representation.
3 One group disproportionately dominant in power.
4 Power concentrated in one group; others largely excluded.
5 A narrow ethnic or sectarian elite monopolises power.

E Restrictions on religious freedom

1 Free religious practice for all.
2 Minor administrative limits.
3 Notable restrictions on some religious groups.
4 Severe restrictions or harassment of a group.
5 Systematic repression of religious groups.

E · PREVENT — automated indicators & thresholds

Scored automatically from public data. All cut-offs live in the open file `data/prevent.json`.

INDICATOR	UNIT	DIRECTION	1	2	3	4	5	SOURCE
Armed conflict	UCDP deaths, last 12 months	more = higher risk	< 1	1–25	25–250	250–1000	≥ 1000	UCDP
Weak state (infant mortality)	deaths per 1,000 births	more = higher risk	< 10	10–20	20–35	35–55	≥ 55	World Bank
Lack of electoral democracy	V-Dem index 0–1	lower = higher risk	≥ 0.7	0.5–0.7	0.35–0.5	0.2–0.35	< 0.2	V-Dem / OWID
Unlimited executive power	V-Dem index 0–1	lower = higher risk	≥ 0.8	0.6–0.8	0.4–0.6	0.2–0.4	< 0.2	V-Dem / OWID
Weak judicial constraints	V-Dem index 0–1	lower = higher risk	≥ 0.8	0.6–0.8	0.4–0.6	0.2–0.4	< 0.2	V-Dem / OWID
Media censorship	V-Dem index 0–1	lower = higher risk	≥ 0.8	0.6–0.8	0.4–0.6	0.2–0.4	< 0.2	V-Dem / OWID
Women in parliament	% of seats	fewer = higher risk	≥ 30	20–30	15–20	10–15	< 10	World Bank
Low economic development	GDP per capita, PPP $	lower = higher risk	≥ 40000	20000–40000	10000–20000	5000–10000	< 5000	World Bank
Economic downturn	% GDP growth	lower = higher risk	≥ 4	2–4	0–2	-3–0	< -3	World Bank
Population growth	% per year	higher = higher risk	< 0.5	0.5–1	1–1.5	1.5–2.5	≥ 2.5	World Bank
Violence in neighbours	deaths within ~200 km of border	more = higher risk	< 1	1–25	25–100	100–500	≥ 500	UCDP

Low trade openness	trade, % of GDP	lower = higher risk	≥ 150	100–150	60–100	40–60	< 40	World Bank

Bands read against the thresholds; endpoints fall in the higher-risk band. Example: infant mortality scores 1 below 10 per 1,000 and 5 at 55 or more.

F · Scoring rules & integrity

- **Public, verified data only.** Every analyst score must rest on published evidence. Cite the source and date. Never use tips, witness accounts or case files to set a public score.
- **Corroboration.** Test each item to the Berkeley Protocol (source, content, context). A score of 4 or 5 needs at least two independent, credible sources.
- **Err low.** Between two levels, choose the lower and note the uncertainty.
- **Do not override automation without reason.** If an analyst changes an automated score, record why, with sources.
- **Four-eyes review.** One analyst scores; a second approves before anything is published — the same bar as a country assessment. Automated jumps of more than one step are held for this review.
- **Re-score on new evidence.** Update when the situation changes; keep the source and date so the trend is auditable.
- **Triggers are flags, not scores in the index.** List them as dated events with sources; they signal timing, not structural level.

Scarecrow Watch is an independent, non-profit, open-source early-warning watch for Southeast Asia. Frameworks: UN Office on Genocide Prevention — Framework of Analysis for Atrocity Crimes (2014); Auschwitz Institute for the Prevention of Genocide and Mass Atrocities (AIPG) — PREVENT. This rubric is Scarecrow's own adaptation, published for transparency; it is not an official UN or AIPG publication.